UMKLAI AREA INTEGRATED COOPERATIVE SOCIETY

Scrubbing away poverty to prosperity through Sohprew the Indigenous Loofah

Umklai village, a small quiet hamlet lying a little off the main road from the hustle and bustle of the national highway ,skirting the busy Nongpoh market is fairly nondescript ,as villages go, but on the slopes surrounding the little hamlet ,dangling from clumps of trees is a wonder plant-the **sohprew**

Used centuries ago, by the Khasis as a natural body scrubber, sponge gourd ,or the humble Sohprew as the Khasis call it, has today metamorphosed in its modern avatar into an eco friendly loofah, which has a huge demand both in the domestic & foreign market .As per recent reports, globally the demand for the organic loofah is 50 lakhs annually, and Meghalaya presently produces only about 1.5 lakhs which reflects the huge potential and market.

It is a niche product which has become an indispensible item of both use & luxury in various categories of spas &resorts. It is commonly sold unpeeled in its raw form at various markets and *haats* in the Khasi and Jaintia Hills.

It's a widely known that everyday we shed 4% of our skin cells. This is a natural regenerative process. If however the dead skin is allowed to remain, it settles as a thick layer and becomes impervious to moisturizers. Exfoliation involves vigorous skin massage, either with the hand ,a body brush, loofah or mitt. Loofahs are highly effective in stimulating blood circulation, loosening dead cells and leaving the skin, soft, supple and glowing. Exfoliation also loosens the blockages that help decrease the likelihood of ingrown hairs. Loofah 's help shed the dull surface cells to give the skin a finer texture, and better colour, besides improving circulation. Loofahs also softens those areas prone to hard skins, such as heels, knees, and elbows .Overall Loofahs have a highly therapeutic effect& more so,in the case of *Sohpew,* which is organic and natural!

The **Umklai Area Integrated Cooperative Society** whose total membership is about 50 members decided to boldly foray into the hitherto un chartered enterprise of mass producing Sohprew -the 100% natural loofah on a commercial basis along with value addition. For this innovative attempt help came in the form of the ICDP(Integrated Cooperative Development Project),financed by the NCDC ,and **facilitated by the Office of the Registrar of Cooperative Societies, under the Cooperation Department.**

An amount of Rs 1.35 lakhs was provided under Share capital Contribution , loan component availed by the Society amounted to Rs 1.65 lakhs, with total project cost amounting to Rs 3.00lakhs.

For long, the members of this society had been growing the sponge gourd in their village and in surrounding areas, thereafter processing the harvested product in its most rudimentary form& selling the same at the local market at Nongpoh , while fetching a very meagre & insubstantial price which was barely enough for subsistence earning. Realizing that this was not enough, and that too much was being spent for so little, Under the Leadership of Bah Him Syngkli, the Chairman of the Society ,the Members applied for a Workshed with Sewing machines, construction of a watertank for soaking ,tools and other paraphernalia in an effort to give value addition to their Sohprew .A more finished and packaged product was gradually fashioned to make the product more designer and user friendly.

Presently, besides, loofahs of different shapes & sizes ,an impressive range of product diversification has occurred , which has dramatically transformed the product range. A plethora of items are now rolling out of this new unit, which include an eclectic array of products that range from one of a kind novelty products like sohprew magnets, enlivened with a hint of orchids, to Sohprew keyrings , sohpro decorative items in the shape of monoliths, pen stands, bathroom slip-ons , and even handbags.

As a vibrant, successful & dynamic cooperative society besides, providing regular dividends to its immediate primary members, this activity is also creating avenues of alternative livelihood for village residents& also playing a significant role towards augmenting additional income of not only for Umklai village but also for the surrounding areas .Employment and jobs are being created through teams of workers who pluck the fruit, peel it, cut ,soak, dry& fashion the Sohpro into shape, etc. Women are generally involved in the sewing and stiching and in the more delicate aspects which go into giving the product a finished look. This overall, is creating a virtuous cycle, which in turn is emboldening the society to attempt newer and more creative products& designs.

To date, Business transaction was to the tune of Rs 4,93,866,and is steadily rising. The Managing Committee of the Society which comprises 7 members, under Bah Him Syngkli informed that they have been regularly participating at Trade fairs and Exhibitions in the Region and also at the national level, where their Sohprew products are proving to be quite a hit. Besides, they have also received several inquiries from interested buyers and orders from Resorts in Assam and from within the state .A Government team visiting Israel also took bulk items to showcase the product to buyers in Israel recently. **It is not surprising to learn that in 2005, at the North East Trade Expo organized by DONER, at Pragati Maidan, New Delhi, the Sohprew won the most Innovative Award.**

The future prospects are bright, and emphasis has to be laid on more product diversification, distribution, generation of adequate volume to meet the demand ,and on better and wider marketing .Another challenge facing the society is easy availability of the raw product, which at present is being grown abundantly only in and around Umklai village.

With this end in mind, the Office of the Registrar of Cooperative Societies, organized a training of Cooperative Societies located in Ri Bhoi District on 23rd-24th Feburary to motivate the surrounding villages to grow the Sohprew so that the Unit could be in a position to source the much needed raw material besides supplementing the income of these villages, through a continuous buy-back agreement.

What is laudable is the humble attempt by a small &determined Cooperative society to market &produce a unique indigenous niche product the Sohprew, which not only is 100% organic and natural but also therapeutic and in great demand in the present day and age where such products are widely in use in homes , spas , resorts& boutique hotels the world over, in a world which is increasingly inclined towards the natural,where organic is not only the flavour & fashion of the day ,but is here to stay as well!


UMKLAI AREA INTEGRATED
COOPERATIVE SOCIETY Ltd
NEDC assisted Project
UNDER I.C.D.P

















